



THE REPUBLIC OF UGANDA

ADDRESS

BY

**H.E YOWERI KAGUTA MUSEVENI
PRESIDENT OF THE REPUBLIC OF UGANDA**

AT THE

**GENERAL DEBATE OF THE 75TH SESSION OF THE
UNITED NATIONS GENERAL ASSEMBLY**

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**President of the UN General Assembly,
Excellencies Heads of State and Government,
Secretary-General of the United Nations,
Distinguished delegates,
Ladies and Gentlemen,**

Mr. President,

I wish to congratulate you on your election as President of the 75th Session of the UN General Assembly and assure you of Uganda's full support. I would like to thank H.E. Tijjan Muhammad-Bande for his exceptional leadership of the 74th Session, particularly during the COVID-19 pandemic period. I pay tribute to the Secretary-General, H.E. António Guterres, for his dedication and commitment to the work of the United Nations. I express my solidarity to all countries that are fighting the COVID-19 pandemic and extend my condolences for the lives lost.

Uganda welcomes the theme of 75th Session of the General Assembly. The United Nations is a fitting forum to speak with one voice on this global pandemic. This Session is a timely reminder of the vision, shared principles and commitments agreed upon at our Summit held in New York



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from September 25-27, 2015. When we adopted the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development, we pledged to ensure “*no one will be left behind*” by taking explicit action to end extreme poverty and curb inequalities.

As we celebrate the 75th anniversary of the United Nations, we, therefore, require an organization that is fit for purpose to address global challenges. It is through effective multilateral action that we can mitigate the multi-faceted impacts of the unprecedented COVID-19 and also support accelerating the implementation of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development. In this regard, Uganda reiterates its commitment to multilateralism. We see multilateralism as a means to address the complex and newly emerging threats and challenges like the COVID-19 pandemic, which has affected every member of the international community, in an increasingly interdependent world.

Mr. President,

Uganda, like many countries around the world, has had to respond to the onslaught of the pandemic. We viewed COVID-19 as a fearless foe to human life, which needed to be confronted. Our approach to dealing with the pandemic prioritized the protection of human life.



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To ensure that the country responded adequately and mitigated the impact of the COVID19 pandemic, the Government, as a first pragmatic step, developed guidelines and standard operating procedures to align and standardize its response. We combined systematic testing, tracing, quarantining and treatment with restrictions on movement and contact – aiming to suppress transmission of the virus. We further combined all this with a widespread media campaign to sensitize the public.

Government has also continued to strengthen its national health system as part of its Universal Health Coverage commitment, to ensure that health facilities that handle COVID-19 patients are well equipped with the necessary supplies, to support efficient and effective case management.

Through these deliberate and targeted decisions, Uganda has been able to prevent mass infections of the Corona virus within the country. Government has also prioritized sustainable recovery from the COVID-19 pandemic in the National COVID-19 Response Strategy.

In addition to its incalculable health and human toll, the pandemic has left an indelible mark on the global economy.



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Across the globe, countries are suffering from the sudden shock to their economies. But beyond the immediate challenges of the current crisis, there is also a need for greater focus on the recovery from this epidemic. The impact of COVID can be mitigated if we act immediately and collectively. We applaud the effort of various international and regional organizations such as the United Nations (UN), World Health Organization (WHO), Non-Aligned Movement (NAM), African Union (AU), Commonwealth, Intergovernmental Authority on Development (IGAD) the East African Community (EAC) and others, in dealing with the pandemic.

We commend the international community for the support so far extended in dealing with this pandemic. The decisions of the IMF, the World Bank Group, and the G20 last April to immediately suspend debt service payments of 76 countries for one year, was laudable. However, the agreed suspension of debt is not enough to respond and recover from the COVID-19 pandemic, including, to navigate its devastating social and economic impacts. We call for more action on comprehensive debt relief package, particularly debt cancellations by multilateral and



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bilateral creditors to enable us have required funding for COVID-19 pandemic response.

I am glad to inform Member Countries that key sectors of Uganda's economy, especially agriculture and ICT, have endured through the COVID-19 pandemic. Production levels increased exceeding pre-COVID-19 levels. Coffee exports continued to surge despite the Corona virus pandemic with April 2020 figures, showing growth compared with a year ago. Uganda has been able to stand up and weather this storm because of the correct actions we took as Government, including the correct policy on promoting private sector-led growth.

The COVID-19 crisis has given us a few lessons and areas for reflection.

First, it shows how interconnected and interdependent our world has become.

Second, we must embrace the digital age and adopt more digital technologies for both production and services, such as banking, retailing, and learning, as well as public services.



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Third, many industries and institutions have the ability to adapt and redirect themselves. In Uganda, clothing factories are making masks, Universities have started making ventilators, and Sugar refineries are manufacturing hand sanitizers.

Mr. President,

Uganda has demonstrated her commitment to scale up its national efforts towards the realization of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development and the 17 Sustainable Development Goals. In the wake of the on-going COVID-19 pandemic, we realize now, more than ever, the need to remain focused on the critical efforts to achieve the overarching 2030 Agenda goal of eradicating poverty in all its forms and dimensions and to spur socio, economic and political development.

Progress has been registered in the implementation of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development, as reflected in our second Voluntary National Review report, which was presented during the 2020 High-Level Political Forum. In this regard, Uganda adopted its Third Five Year National Development Plan (NDPIII) 2020/2021- 2024/2025 under



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Development Plan (NDPIII) 2020/2021- 2024/2025 under the theme "*Sustainable industrialization for inclusive growth, employment and wealth creation*". The Plan emphasizes key interventions under broad transformative categories, including environmental protection, governance, and industrialization for implementation, working closely with development partners and other relevant stakeholders, particularly in the context of 'build-back-better' recovery from the COVID-19 pandemic. It prioritizes the elimination of the 'silo' approach to service delivery and enhances synergies across sectors and other actors in the implementation of national sustainable development priorities and policies.

Mr. President,

Climate change remains one of the greatest challenges of our time. We continue to witness climate change disasters across the globe that results in considerable loss of lives and property. It is clear that no country is immune to these disasters. Addressing climate change calls for effective and bold multilateral actions by us all. Uganda, for example, continues to experience prolonged droughts, melting of ice caps at its highest mountain, Mt. Ruwenzori,



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floods, erratic rainfall and landslides. Recently, the country experienced impacts of intensive and prolonged rainfall which caused a rise in water levels of major water bodies and flooding in several areas of the country.

The Government will continue to invest in climate adaptation and mitigation measures that include, inter alia: increasing access and consumption of clean energy to enhance production and increasing forest and wetland cover, among others, in line with our ambitious Nationally Determined Contributions. These investments will enable us to stop, reduce and reverse environmental degradation and the adverse effects of climate change as well as improve sustainable use of natural resources for inclusive economic growth.

Mobilizing the means of implementation for climate change, mitigation and adaptation, including resilience, remains critical particularly, at the international level in addressing climate change. In this regard, Uganda will support bold action proposals at the 26th Session of the Conference of the Parties to the UN Framework Convention on Climate Change scheduled in 2021 in the areas of mitigation, adaptation and finance. We, therefore, urge the developed



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countries to fulfill their financial commitment in line with the Paris Agreement to provide 100 billion US Dollars annually by 2020, to assist developing country Parties with respect to both mitigation and adaptation.

We equally continue to witness an increasing trend in biodiversity loss where wildlife and other living species are under the danger of extinction. We all rely heavily on the planet for our livelihoods. In this regard, we should, therefore, recommit our determination to protect the planet from degradation, including, through sustainable production and consumption and sustainably managing its natural resources, so that it can support the needs of the present and future generations.

Mr. President,

As the United Nations commemorates its 75th anniversary, Uganda joins the community of nations in acknowledging the legitimacy, convening power, normative impact and undeniable successes that our shared vision can achieve. Alot, however, remains to be done to further strengthen international cooperation in achieving the three interrelated and interdependent goals of: global and regional peace and



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security; sustainable economic development for all; and the advancement of human rights and dignity.

This 75th anniversary year also marks the end of the Third Decade for the Eradication of Colonialism, at a time when 17 non-self-governing territories still remain on the books, with regard to the implementation of the declaration on the granting of Independence to Colonial countries and Peoples. The unresolved question of Western Sahara remains the single issue that stands in the way of the total eradication of colonialism on the African Continent. Uganda, therefore, joins the international community in underscoring its commitment to the principles and practices that are enshrined in the Charter of the United Nations, including the principles of equal rights and self-determination of peoples.

Mr. President,

The General Assembly approved the Quadrennial Comprehensive Policy Review (QCPR) of the operational activities for the development of the United Nations system and the repositioning of the United Nations Development System (UNDS) in 2016 and 2018 respectively, to make the



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the UNDS more strategic, accountable, transparent, collaborative, efficient, effective and result-oriented. The approval arose out of the need to position the United Nations operational activities for development to support countries in their national efforts to implement the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development. We commend the Secretary-General for the progress so far made in implementing the approved reforms in consultation with the Member States. Uganda will work within the G77/China during the next cycle of the Quadrennial comprehensive policy review of operational activities for the development of the United Nations System to ensure that the UNDS gets appropriate policy guidance for the next four years to support countries accelerate the implementation of the 2030 Agenda in their jurisdictions.

Mr. President,

South-South Co-operation has continued to prove itself as an important element of international co-operation in addressing global challenges in the global South, particularly, during the current COVID-19 pandemic. Countries in the global South have received support from their global counterparts, which has enhanced their national as well as regional capabilities in



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responding to the unprecedented COVID-19 pandemic. Cognizant of the critical role of South-South Co-operation in the implementation of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development, Uganda will continue to support the strengthening of South-South Co-operation among the G77/China Members and within the United Nations, in line with its principles. As the Third South Summit host, I look forward to welcoming the G77/China leaders to the Third South Summit in Kampala, Uganda on the suitable dates in 2021.

Mr. President,

Uganda applauds the Secretary-General for his timely Appeal for a Global Ceasefire during the COVID19 pandemic. There is no doubt that the pandemic has globally impacted on all aspects of our lives - social, economic and political and in almost all countries across the globe. And with continued armed conflicts and wars, the pandemic makes, an already worse situation, more dire.

Africa's continental and sub-regional organizations have continued to play a critical role in conflict prevention and



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crisis management across the continent. I welcome the direct partnership and engagement between the United Nations (UN) and the African Union (AU) on peace and security matters, which has accelerated in recent years. Our experience has shown that, where the international community and the UN, in particular, have supported regional efforts, they have been successful. We should encourage and strengthen this partnership.

Uganda continues to support and advance peace and security efforts in the region. We are fully aware that the prosperity and development of countries in our region and beyond is inextricably linked to peace and security. We remain actively involved in regional initiatives, such as those of the IGAD, EAC, ICGLR, AU and are encouraged by the progress we see. We will continue to support the peace efforts under these frameworks like in South Sudan, the political transition in Sudan and the stabilization efforts in Somalia.

Mr. President,

The threat of terrorism remains a security challenge of our time. We should be mindful that while COVID-19 and



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several measures taken by Governments around the globe may have contributed to the suppression of the activities of violent extremist and terrorist groups, the new “normal” created by the crisis can also play into the hands of violent extremist and terrorist groups.

Uganda remains committed to supporting global and regional counter-terrorism efforts. In our own region, terrorist groups like Al-Shabaab, Boko Haram, ISIS, Al Qaida and the Allied Democratic Forces (ADF), continue to be a threat to our common security and development. Neutralizing these groups requires cooperative and firm responses.

Mr. President,

After 75 years of the existence of the United Nations, the need to reform the Security Council is more urgent and imperative now than ever before. The present geopolitical realities, such as the global health pandemic, are compelling reasons for a comprehensive reform of the Security Council. Reform will further enhance the authority and efficiency of the Council.



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After 75 years, we should take bold steps to address this long-standing injustice and imbalance in the present configuration of the Security Council. We should make way for equitable representation of unrepresented and under-represented regions, especially the African region.

African issues dominate the agenda of the Council. Still, it remains the only region without representation in the Permanent Category of the Security Council, and also under-represented in the Non-permanent category. We should demonstrate the political will to redress the historical injustice done to the African continent. We, therefore, urge all Member States to work towards achieving progress for a comprehensive reform of the Security Council.

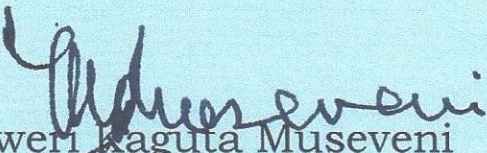
Finally, later this year an important election will be held for judges of the International Court of Justice, one of the key organs of our organization. Uganda accepted the compulsory jurisdiction of the World Court without any reservation, way back in March 1963, as a new member of the United Nations family. We are also proud that Judge Julia Sebutinde, from Uganda, the first African woman to serve on the Court, who has served the Court with



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distinction, will be up for re-election for a second and final term. I commend to you Judge Julia Sebutinde and request your support for re-election to her second and final mandate on the International Court of Justice.

I thank you for your attention.


Yoweri Kaguta Museveni

PRESIDENT OF THE REPUBLIC OF UGANDA